

**ENGL 231 03 Film, New Media, and Culture
(Digital Platforms and Infrastructures)
Coastal Carolina University
Spring 2026**

Instructor: Dr. Gayas Eapen

Class times: T/Th 10:50 - 12:05 AM

Class location: 166, Edwards College of Humanities and Fine Arts

Office hours: W 11-1 pm and T, Th 10-10:50 am

Instructor's office: EHFA 209

Email: geapen@coastal.edu

CATALOG DESCRIPTION

This course is designed to provoke and cultivate students' imaginative and critical understanding of film and new media in various cultural contexts. The course promotes an active and critical engagement with film, new media texts, and media innovations as a means for analysis and critique within the broader framework of humanistic inquiry. Texts and films will vary by section.

COURSE DESCRIPTION (Spring 2026)

This course takes the “platforms and infrastructure” route to understand the changes happening across digital media industries, policy, and culture. Throughout the course, we will learn about methods of studying infrastructures and see how digital platforms—such as YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, X, Tiktok and others—intersect with systems of modern living like highways and electrification. We will also analyze issues and trends within big data and artificial intelligence, surveillance technologies, and digital monetization. Course activities will include app-walkthroughs, gestural analysis, infrastructure walks, and intentional self-tracking to understand and study media platforms.

STUDENT LEARNING OUTCOMES

This course will equip students to:

- **Become aware** of changes taking place in the digital media infrastructural and industrial landscape
- **Generate a vocabulary** to analyze media corporations and their ‘platforms’
- **Scrutinize** the issues and dynamics of power embedded in emerging forms of infrastructure
- **Appreciate** nuances of invisible labor, new geopolitical and economic relations, and regulatory regimes globally

LIST OF ASSIGNMENTS AND GRADING BREAKDOWN

1. **App-walkthrough 10%** Students will carry out detailed walkthrough analysis of a mobile phone app of their choice discussing its affordances, interface, and articulation by following guidelines from the readings discussed in this module.
2. **Media Industry Studies presentation (in class) 10%:** Small groups will present a review of industry-oriented works relating to video games, films, and TV. The presentation will be judged on summarizing skills, division of group labor, and clarity.
3. **Gestural analysis of screen interfaces 5%:** During an in-class show and-tell, students will analyze their gestural and bodily practices by analyzing another object that utilizes gestural practices, comparing and contrasting similar practices of computational platforms and interfaces.
4. **Gigwork pop quiz 10%:** Students will be judged on this quiz based on materials covering issues of gigworkers
5. **Personal experience interviews on cloudwork/gigwork 10%:** By carrying out short interviews with friends, family, or acquaintances that have worked in a sector that uses cloudwork or 'gig' work, students will explore the challenges that such work entails.
6. **Infrastructure walk reflection 15%:** After carrying out leisurely walks seeing and studying infrastructure that surrounds them, students will reflect on the values and power infrastructures are embedded with.
7. **Self-tracking assignment or civic platform review 10%:** Students will either track their data sharing and permissions setting to analyze the personal data they voluntarily or involuntarily share with media corporations OR write a review of a city, state, or federal platform that has become infrastructural to their lives.
8. **Final assignment – Intervening in issues of media platforms and infrastructure 20%:** By focusing on one issue discussed throughout the semester (for instance surveillance or datafication), students will create a campaign that will attempt to address that issue within a targeted community. They will draft a plan to intervene within these issues and execute the intervention using multimedia creative methods. The drafts will be presented to the classroom and will be submitted along with a reflection.
9. **Participation and attendance 10%:** Points based on student participation in class, responding to discussion questions, responding to peers, and providing feedback to classmates.

Detailed assignment descriptions will be posted to Moodle and discussed in class.

CLASS RESOURCES AND TECHNOLOGY

All readings utilized in this course will be provided in the Moodle page of the course or will be accessible through the CCU's library website.

ATTENDANCE POLICY

Students are expected to attend all class sessions and on time. I will be strictly following the university's guidelines on attendance. If you miss more than seven class sessions in total during the course, you will automatically receive an 'F' grade unless they are all exempted by the exemptions outlined in the university's attendance policy found [here](#). I will give three unexcused absences—which means you don't need to give me any proof for being excused; you will however need to inform me that you have been or will be absent from class. Any other absences will need to be excused and will require proof.

EMAIL POLICY

Email is the best place to reach me for any concerns including excused or emergency unexcused absences from scheduled classes. For all other academic questions, I will take 24-48 hours to get back to you during the work week. For assignment related questions, please plan to ask questions prior to the submission date to avoid any last-minute confusion. I will do my best to respond to all emails in a timely manner. However, I would encourage you to consult the syllabus and the course Moodle page before contacting me. If an email is just a notification or intimation (for e.g. I am running a few minutes late), I might not respond to it.

OFFICE HOURS

Classrooms aren't always a democratic space for everyone. However, office hours give you the opportunity to speak to me one-on-one in a judgement-free environment. I would like to see you drop by at least once during the course of the semester. Use office hours to clarify doubts, bring a concern to my attention, or even discuss a random (news) event which might have interested you and you might have an opinion about. Basically, there are no bad reasons to show up for office hours.

LATE ASSIGNMENT POLICY

Assignments will need to be turned in on time. Most assignments for this course are due at 5 pm on Fridays during the week when an assignment is due. I will allow two excused extensions for assignment by 24-48 hours in case of exceptional circumstances. I will not need any proof (medical records) or permission letters for such extensions. However, you will need to request such an extension. Any other extension requests will be considered on a case-by-case basis and are solely at the instructor's discretion. However, if in doubt, please check-in with me! No extensions are possible for the last assignment of the course. This is so I can turn in the final grades on time. Please be mindful of this.

PARTICIPATION

Students are expected to pay attention to their peers and me while they are present in the classroom. Participation is often assessed as response to discussion questions posed in the classroom. However, it can be daunting for some to speak up in class. If you feel like you are unable to participate in the classroom during class discussion or during in-class activities, please reach out to me for alternative participation options.

TECH POLICY

Devices can be used for the purpose of notetaking and for class activities. In fact, you'd often be unable to work without them. But texting, listening to music, or online shopping is discouraged while class is in session. All rules have exceptions. If you are doing a creative activity while we are in class and need some white noise, music, or even need to leave the space briefly, this can be accommodated. I encourage you to check-in with me for these options!

AI POLICY

This course doesn't outrightly ban the use of AI tools that have recently become popular including ChatGPT, Bard, Dall E, Midjourney, Perplexity, and so on. However, their use is **only selectively permitted**, primarily to enhance learning instead of hindering it. **In any scenario, using generative AI for completing the entirety of, or majority of, the project or assignment is not permitted.** Please consult with the instructor before proceeding if you have any confusion. Passing off the work of a text, image, sound, or code generator as your own is also not acceptable in any scenario. If you are using generative AI tools in a part of an assignment, acknowledge the extent of it along with a rationale of 'Why I used AI here' in a short sentence or two before submitting it.

Scenarios where AI use *is* recommended:

- To generate potential ideas but later enhancing them, and rewriting them, on your own.
- To clarify terms while reading an article. For terms with intellectual histories such as theoretical or philosophical concepts, make sure you double check a reliable source such as an encyclopedia.
- To create a scaffolding for piece of generic writing: For e.g., "Can you tell me what components to include in my final portfolio?"
- Reducing time for web-research/browsing. For e.g., "Can you suggest me three of the most used tools that are used by professionals in the field of video production to host their portfolios?"

Scenarios where AI use *is not* allowed in this course:

- For creating storyboard using software-based generators
- For writing scripts or discussion responses due in class
- For writing reflections or generating discussion questions, takeaway summaries that will be used in class
- For generating an assignment or its draft by writing a prompt into text generator

ACCESSIBILITY & DISABILITY POLICY

Coastal Carolina University is committed to equitable access and inclusion of individuals with disabilities in accordance with the Americans with Disabilities Act and Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act. Individuals seeking reasonable accommodations should contact Accessibility and Disability Services 843-349-2503 or <https://www.coastal.edu/disabilityservices/>.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Students in this course are expected to follow Coastal Carolina's standards of academic integrity and to uphold the Coastal Carolina honor and integrity code.

Keep in mind that plagiarism, cheating, and attempted cheating are all forms of academic dishonesty, and none of these activities will be tolerated in this course. Academic dishonesty will be dealt with through the procedures outlined in the Coastal Carolina [Academic Integrity Code](#).

CLASSROOM CONDUCT

This classroom is intended to be a safe and inclusive space for people from different backgrounds and contexts. Everyone is expected to be respectful and kind to each other, even if you disagree with someone else's opinions or views. However, hate or discriminatory speech of any kind including racist, homophobic, classist, sexist, among others, will not be tolerated in the classroom.

RESOURCES AVAILABLE TO STUDENTS

1. University libraries: <https://libraries.coastal.edu/home>.
2. The John Cage (for borrowing equipment like mics, cameras, 3D printers): <https://www.coastal.edu/humanities/resources/thejohncage/>
3. CINO pantry (resources for food insecure students): <https://www.coastal.edu/osl/leadership/civicengagement/cinopantry/>
4. Counselling center (offers free counselling sessions for students via student health): <https://www.coastal.edu/counseling/>
5. International Student Services (resources and support for international students): <https://www.coastal.edu/internationalstudents/iss/>
6. Academic success center (offers tutoring, coaching, and advice on issues like time-management, procrastination, etc.): <https://www.coastal.edu/studentssuccesscenter/>
7. Writing Center (offers one-on-one consultation on student writing work): <https://www.coastal.edu/writingcenter/>
8. Student Health Services (primary care, prevention and education services, Covid-19 testing and vaccinations): <https://www.coastal.edu/health/>